

Instructions: Read the passage provided and answer the following questions.

Gerry came upstairs from the computer room and met Sara, who works in marketing.

“Hi, how’re you doing?” he asked.

“Fine” she answered. “We just had a great meeting discussing the new web site. We want to add some new features that will allow personalization of the home page for our regular customers”. She knew that Gerry would be interested.

He was. “That’s great—when can we get started? I've been playing with XML and the new secure server platform and I'm sure we can work up some great ideas for you ...”.

Sara wondered exactly what “XML” might be and whether this was the seventh or eight new server that the IT department has bought for themselves this year. She then wondered where the conversation might go next, and decided to cut and run.

“Yeah, sure! Let’s meet soon and talk about that” she called as she turned to go down the corridor to her office in the marketing department.

Questions:

1. Who are the characters in this passage? What departments do they work for?
2. For each character, which part of the conversation do they clearly care about? How about the parts they don't understand?
3. What is the core problem of this conversation? What were the goals, language, and priorities of all parties involved? Do they connect?
4. Sara walked away before any requirements were agreed upon. Imagine that Gerry starts building the new personalized homepage tomorrow using only what he heard in this conversation. List three specific things that could go wrong with the final product from Sara's perspective.
5. As a consultant hired by this company, recommend **one practical change** on how the different teams in this passage interact.